

TOP10 Bossa Nova Guitar Chords

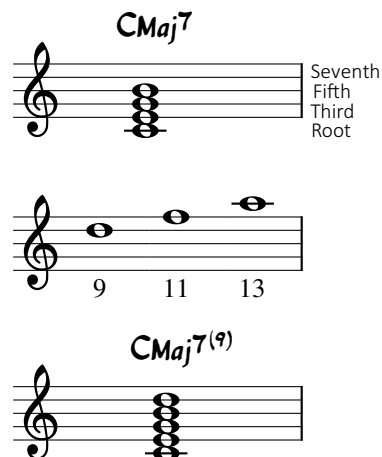
Bossa Nova music is famous for its soft and warm-sounding chords. On the following pages you will find ten very useful and common Bossa Nova chords. For each chord, there is a practice pattern and you will find detailed examples of famous Bossa Nova songs at the end of the document.

CHORD THEORY IN A NUTSHELL

The chords used in bossa nova songs are often four-part chords with an extension tone that adds additional color to the chords. This C-Major7 chord is such a four-part chord. It is called a seventh chord because the four chord tones are called: Root, Third, Fifth and SEVENTH

These are the possible extension tones to color the chord. Popular are the ninth (9) and eleventh (11) for minor and major four-part chords, as well as the thirteenth (13) for diminished and dominant seventh chords.

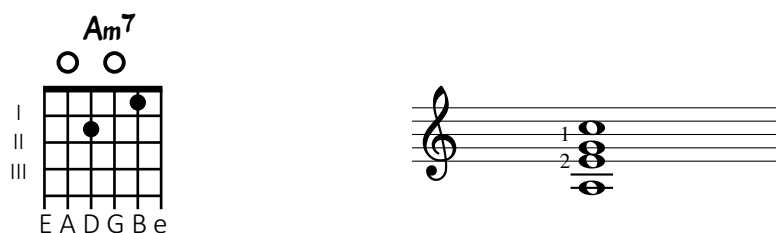
This is a CMaj7 chord with extension tone D. The nine (9) is written in paranthesis behind the chord symbol.



Guitar chords often have a different structure than for example piano chords. For easier understanding, the chords are shown in diagrams as well as standard notation and TABs.

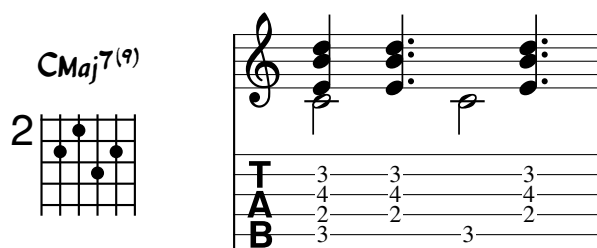
The diagrams show the guitar neck with the strings being the vertical lines and the frets being the horizontal lines.

The fingerings for the chords are written in numbers in the standard notation. Here is an example:



You can see the Am7 chord displayed in the diagram and the same notes in standard notation. You are supposed to pluck the middle four strings. The A- and G-String are to be played as open strings (white dots on top), while your fingers press the 2nd fret on the D-String as well as the first fret on the B-String. In the notation you can see four notes, the lowest being the open A-String. The number 2 represents the middle finger (to be put on the D-String). The next note has no fingering as it is the open G-String. The number 1 indicates that the index finger is on the B-String.

The examples on the following pages are written with TABs but the rhythmic information is mostly displayed in standard notation. Most of these rhythms are explained at www.bossanova-gitarre.de.

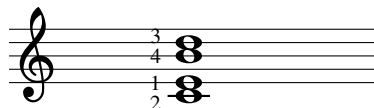
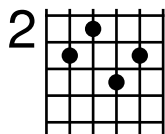


In order not to get too lost in theory, here are ten of the most popular, well-known and beautiful bossa nova chords.

1 THE MAJOR SEVENTH CHORD WITH 9

The first chord of Girl from Ipanema and many other pieces. The ninth adds extra warmth to the major triad with a major seventh!

C_{Maj}7⁽⁹⁾



Suggested Practice Pattern:

C_{Maj}7⁽⁹⁾



F_{Maj}7⁽⁹⁾



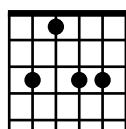
TAB

Chord	T	A	B
C _{Maj} 7 ⁽⁹⁾	3	4	2
F _{Maj} 7 ⁽⁹⁾	8	9	7

2 THE MINOR SEVENTH CHORD WITH 9

The little sister of the Major9 chord – a bit more mellow and at least as beautiful! The jazz bossa Blue Bossa makes extensive use of this chord.

C_m7⁽⁹⁾



Suggested Practice Pattern:

C_m7⁽⁹⁾



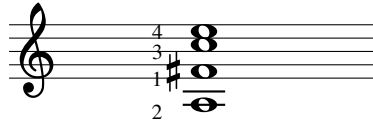
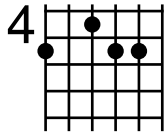
F_m7⁽⁹⁾



TAB

Chord	T	A	B
C _m 7 ⁽⁹⁾	3	3	1
F _m 7 ⁽⁹⁾	8	8	6

Am⁶



Am⁶

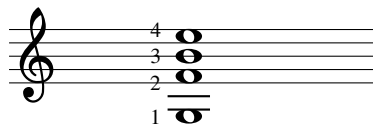
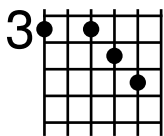


Dm7(9)



4 THE DOMINANT SEVENTH CHORD WITH 13

G7(13)



Dm7(9)



G7(13)



Dm7(9)



G7(13)

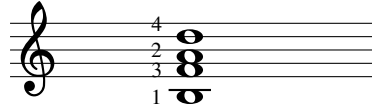
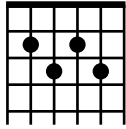


The first system of the musical score for 'The Wind' consists of two staves. The top staff is a treble clef with a key signature of one flat (B-flat). It contains a melody starting with a quarter note G4, followed by a half note F4, a quarter note E4, a quarter note D4, a quarter note C4, a quarter note B3, a quarter note A3, and a quarter note G3. The bottom staff is a bass clef with a key signature of one flat. It contains a bass line starting with a quarter note G3, followed by a half note F3, a quarter note E3, a quarter note D3, a quarter note C3, a quarter note B2, a quarter note A2, and a quarter note G2. The system ends with a double bar line and repeat dots on both staves.

5

THE HALF DIMINISHED CHORD

As part of the most important cadence in minor (= fundamental chord progression, in this case the II-V-I), the half diminished chord is an important part of many bossa nova and jazz songs.

Bm7^{b5}

Suggested Practice Pattern:

Diagram showing a suggested practice pattern for the half diminished chord progression (Am - Bm7^{b5} - E7). The pattern is written in treble and bass staves with tablature below.

Am (Fretboard diagram: 1st fret, 2nd string; 2nd fret, 3rd string; 3rd fret, 4th string)

Bm7^{b5} (Fretboard diagram: 1st fret, 2nd string; 2nd fret, 3rd string; 3rd fret, 4th string; 4th fret, 5th string)

E7 (Fretboard diagram: 1st fret, 2nd string; 2nd fret, 3rd string; 3rd fret, 4th string; 4th fret, 5th string)

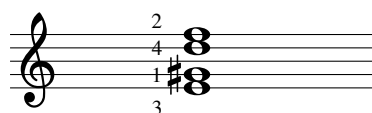
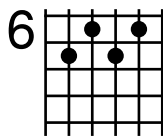
Tablature (TAB) shows the sequence of notes and frets for each chord, including rests and fingerings.

6

THE DOMINANT SEVENTH CHORD WITH FLAT NINE

Along with the half-diminished chord, the Dom7(b9) chord forms the “minor cadence” team.

Here is another example for the minor cadence. You can enrich the E7 chord with a flat ninth and expand the timbre.

E7(b9)

Suggested Practice Pattern:

Diagram showing a suggested practice pattern for the minor cadence (Am⁶ - Bm7^{b5} - E7(b9)). The pattern is written in treble and bass staves with tablature below.

Am⁶ (Fretboard diagram: 1st fret, 2nd string; 2nd fret, 3rd string; 3rd fret, 4th string; 4th fret, 5th string)

Bm7^{b5} (Fretboard diagram: 1st fret, 2nd string; 2nd fret, 3rd string; 3rd fret, 4th string; 4th fret, 5th string)

E7(b9) (Fretboard diagram: 1st fret, 2nd string; 2nd fret, 3rd string; 3rd fret, 4th string; 4th fret, 5th string)

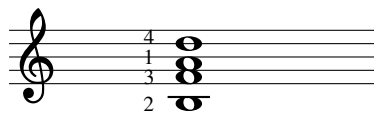
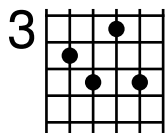
Tablature (TAB) shows the sequence of notes and frets for each chord, including rests and fingerings.

7

THE DIMINISHED SEVENTH CHORD

The Secret Weapon of Bossa Nova! Tom Jobim uses the diminished chord in numerous songs. These chords, which often occur as passing chords, can be used in many ways due to their ambiguity.

C#°7



Suggested Practice Pattern:

Practice pattern for C#°7, CMaj7, C#°7, Dm7(9), and G13 chords. The pattern is shown in both musical notation and TAB notation.

CMaj7 **C#°7** **Dm7(9)** **G13**

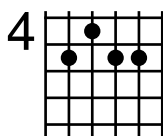
The pattern consists of four measures, each containing a chord and a suggested practice pattern. The TAB notation shows the fret numbers for each string (1-6) and the duration of each note.

8

THE DOMINANT SEVENTH CHORD WITH 9

Dominant Seventh chords are vital to chord progressions of any music genre. No wonder there are a total of four different chords of this type in the list. The Dom7(9) chord is probably the most common and it is also a typical sound in blues and funk music.

D7(9)



Suggested Practice Pattern:

Practice pattern for Am7 and D7(9) chords. The pattern is shown in both musical notation and TAB notation.

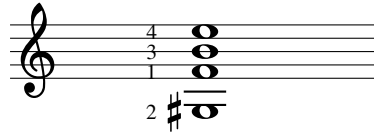
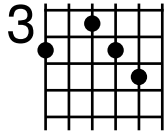
Am7 **D7(9)**

The pattern consists of two measures, each containing a chord and a suggested practice pattern. The TAB notation shows the fret numbers for each string (1-6) and the duration of each note.

9

THE DIMINISHED SEVENTH CHORD WITH b13

In order to make the diminished chord a little softer, you can give the voicing an extension tone. Especially the diminished chord with b13 is often played by Joao Gilberto. For example in Corcovado:

G#°7(b13)

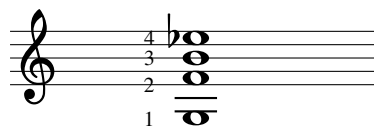
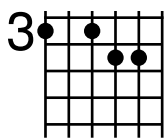
Suggested Practice Pattern:

Am⁶**G#°7(b13)**

10

THE DOMINANT SEVENTH CHORD WITH b13

This chord structure is identical to #4 but with a flattened thirteenth. In theory this chord resolves to a minor chord. In Jazz & Bossa Nova music this type of chord is also used to create a strong tension/resolution effect to a major chord.

G7(b13)

Suggested Practice Pattern:

C#m7b5**F#7(b13)****Bm7(9)****Bm7(9)**

EXAMPLES

The following examples are short passages extracted from well-known Bossa Nova Standards. These will give you an idea how to incorporate the TOP10 Chords into a Bossa Nova chord arrangement.

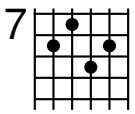
1 THE GIRL FROM IPANEMA

The Girl From Ipanema is probably the most famous bossa nova song.

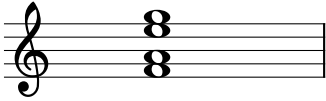
The middle part of the piece in particular is an excursion into the shifting of tonal centers, but you can play the first part with just a few very similar chord voicings.

TOP10 BOSSA NOVA CHORDS

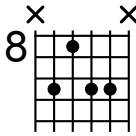
F^{Maj}7⁽⁹⁾



#1



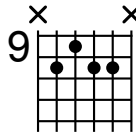
G^m7⁽⁹⁾



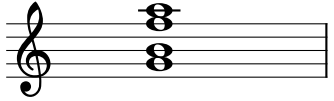
#2



G⁷(9)



#8



Example: Bars 1-8 of The Girl from Ipanema

F^{Maj}7⁽⁹⁾

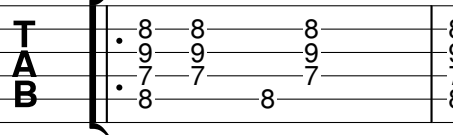


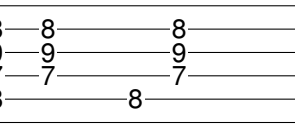
G⁷(9)

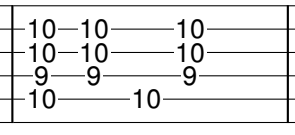


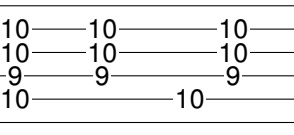
Tall and tan and young — and love - ly, The Girl From I - pa - ne - ma goes walk - ing, and when

TAB









G^m7⁽⁹⁾



G^b7⁽⁹⁾



F^{Maj}7⁽⁹⁾

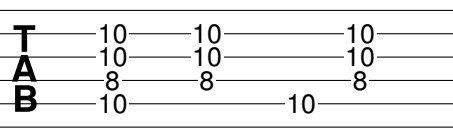


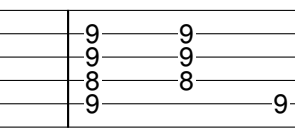
G^bMaj7⁽⁹⁾

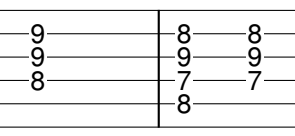


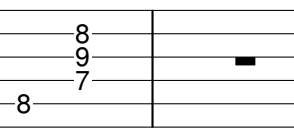
— she pass - es, each one — she pass - es goes "aah!"

TAB







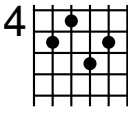


2 SO DANCO SAMBA

"I only dance samba" and yet it's bossa nova! Tom Jobims pieces often contain more complex chord progressions but here he uses the simple structure of a typical jazz standard. In the key of D major there is a beautiful guitar accompaniment with simple but very typical Bossa Nova chords.

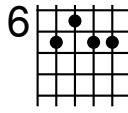
TOP10 BOSSA NOVA CHORDS

DMaj7⁽⁹⁾



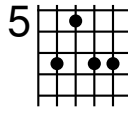
#1 

E7⁽⁹⁾



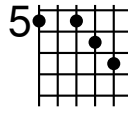
#8 

Em7⁽⁹⁾



#2 

A7⁽¹³⁾



#4 

Example: Bars 1-8 of So Danco Samba

DMaj7⁽⁹⁾



E7⁽⁹⁾



So dan - ço sam - ba só dan - ço sam - ba Vai, vai, vai, vai, vai SÓ

TAB

5	5	5	5	5	5	7	7	7	7	7	7
6	6	6	6	6	6	7	7	7	7	7	7
4	4	4	4	4	4	6	6	6	6	6	6
5	5	5	5	5	5	7	7	7	7	7	7

Em7⁽⁹⁾



A7⁽¹³⁾



DMaj7⁽⁹⁾



DMaj7⁽⁹⁾



dan - ço sam - ba, só dan - ço sam - ba Vai

TAB

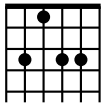
7	7	7	7	7	7	5	5	5	5	5	5
7	7	7	7	7	7	6	6	6	6	6	6
5	5	5	5	5	5	4	4	4	4	4	4
7	7	7	7	7	7	5	5	5	5	5	5

3 BLUE BOSSA

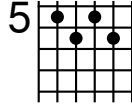
Blue Bossa is the most famous Jazz-Bossa tune and a popular song for Jam Sessions and improvisations. The short form (the piece is only 16 bars long) and the simple but catchy melody are certainly important reasons for this success.

TOP10 BOSSA NOVA CHORDS

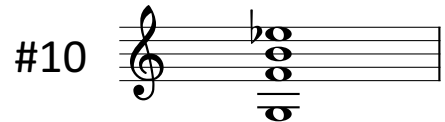
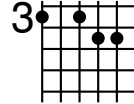
Cm7⁽⁹⁾



Dm7^{b5}



G7(b9)



Example: Bars 1-8 of Blue Bossa

Cm⁹



Fm⁹



Musical notation and guitar tablature for the first 8 bars of Blue Bossa. The notation is in G major (one flat) and 4/4 time. The tablature shows fingerings and string numbers for each measure.

Dm7^{b5}



G7(b9)



Cm⁹



Musical notation and guitar tablature for the last 8 bars of Blue Bossa. The notation is in G major (one flat) and 4/4 time. The tablature shows fingerings and string numbers for each measure.

4 MANHA DE CARNAVAL

The guitarist Luiz Bonfá has set a monument with Manha de Carnaval. It is one of the most popular pieces for getting started in the world of bossa nova.

TOP10 BOSSA NOVA CHORDS

Am⁶ Bm⁷^{b5} E7^(b9) Dm⁷⁽⁹⁾ G7⁽¹³⁾

#3 #5 #6 #2 #4

Example: Bars 1-8 of Manha de Carnaval

Am⁶ Bm⁷^{b5} E7^(b9) Am⁶ Bm⁷^{b5} E7^(b9)

A day in the life of a fool A

sad and a long lonely day

TAB

5 ONCE I LOVED

More from Jobim! Once I Loved features several key changes and makes extensive use of the diminished chord. It is a very suitable song to get your chord playing to the next level.

TOP10 BOSSA NOVA CHORDS

Dm⁷⁽⁹⁾

#2

G7⁽¹³⁾

#4

C#°7

#7

Example: Bars 1-8 of Once I Loved

Dm⁹

G7⁽¹³⁾

CMaj⁷

C#°7

Once I Loved, And I

T	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5
B	5	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3

Dm⁹

D#°7

Em⁷⁽⁹⁾

gave so much love to this love, it was the world to me.

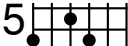
T	5	5	5	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7
B	5	3	3	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7

TOP10 BOSSA NOVA CHORDS

#9

Bb^o7

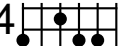
5



#3

Am⁶

4



Bm7

7

B $\flat$ 7

5

How in - sen - si - tive I must have seemed

TAB

Am6

4

E7/G#

2

When he told me that he loved me

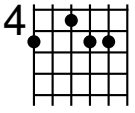
TAB

7 CORCOVADO

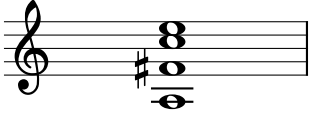
Astrud Gilberto sings "Quiet Night of Quiet Stars" in 1963 and the world is still at her feet today. It remains one of the most recorded Bossa Nova songs until today..

TOP10 BOSSA NOVA CHORDS

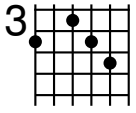
Am⁶



#3



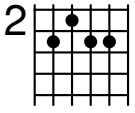
G#m7(b13)



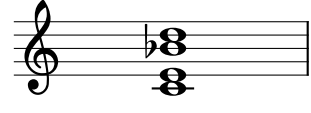
#9



C7(9)



#8



Example: Bars 1-8 of Corcovado

Am⁶



G#m7(b13)



Um can - ti-nho, um vi o - lão Es - te_a mor, u - ma can - ção

TAB	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5
	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5
	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4
	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	5

Gm7



C7(9)



Fmaj7



Pra fa - zer fe - liz a quem se a - ma

TAB	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3